

identification number (PIN) as you enter it. The thieves then skim money from your bank account. Stick to bank ATMs instead of those in malls, airports, and other public places.

The ATM can be an expensive way to check your balance or recent transactions, at \$1.00 or \$1.50 a pop at some banks. The receipt you get when you make another type of ATM transaction, such as withdrawing cash or making a deposit, often shows your account balance, so why pay extra?

Minimizing ATM Fees

You probably don't keep track of what you pay in ATM fees over the course of a year, but you can see how these fees can add up quickly, so it could be a substantial amount. Simply being aware of how you use the ATM can help you plan ahead so you can avoid some of the costs. Here are a few other ideas for avoiding fees:

- Establish an account at a bank with a large ATM network so you don't get stuck using out-of-network ATMs.
- Plan cash withdrawals when you can access your own bank's ATMs, or look for ATMs that don't impose a surcharge (usually indicated on the ATM).
- Withdraw large amounts of cash less often rather than smaller amounts more often.
- If your bank doesn't charge to use a live teller, use a teller instead of the ATM.
- Use personal checks instead of paying cash.
- Double up transactions, such as using your ATM card to get cash back when you make a purchase at a point-of-sale cash register.
- When traveling, use traveler's checks, personal checks, or credit cards.
- Avoid higher-cost ATMs found in convenience stores, hotels, casinos, restaurants, and airports.